ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

ENG 101: Nigerian Literature in English - Texts, Contexts and Close Reading

A reading method for the novels, plays and poems on your first-year list

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
English Language & Literature | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

First-year literature is not about memorising plots; it is about making defensible claims from evidence. This pack covers the historical shaping of Nigerian literature in English, the shift from cultural nationalism to critique of the nation, and a close-reading method you can apply to any text on the list.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Place a text in the phases of Nigerian literary history.
- Distinguish close reading from plot summary.
- Analyse narrative voice, imagery and structure.
- Build an argument supported by quotation.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

A short map of the field

Know the phases well enough to date and situate a text.

- Cultural nationalism and the generation that wrote back to colonial representation.
- Independence-era optimism and its rapid disillusionment.
- Civil war literature and the literature of trauma.
- Postcolonial critique of the nation-state, elite politics and corruption.
- Diaspora writing and the global circulation of Nigerian fiction.
- Contemporary writing on gender, sexuality, migration and technology.

Close reading, step by step

The method is repeatable and it earns marks.

1. Choose a short passage that clearly matters to the text.
2. Note its literal content in one sentence.
3. Analyse diction: which words are unexpected and why?
4. Analyse imagery and figurative language.
5. Analyse syntax and rhythm: short clauses or long accumulations?
6. Connect the passage to a pattern in the whole text and to your argument.

> **Quote precisely**
> A short quotation, correctly embedded and analysed, beats a long block quotation that is never discussed.

Context without overreach

Biography explains less than you think.

- Use history to explain textual choices, not to replace analysis.
- Avoid reading a character as the author's autobiography.
- Note publication date and reception when they matter.
- Treat oral tradition as form and influence, not as background colour.
- Read the introduction and notes, then form your own reading.
- Cite editions consistently.

A literature with a history of argument

Nigerian literature in English begins in contest. The first generation wrote against colonial representation and against the assumption that African life was raw material for European interpretation. Chinua Achebe's Things Fall Apart (1958) answered novels that treated Igbo society as backdrop by placing its institutions, proverbs and internal debates at the centre.

The language question followed immediately. Achebe argued for a "new English" that could carry African experience; Ngugi wa Thiong'o argued that writing in colonial languages perpetuates colonial power and moved to Gikuyu. The debate is not settled, and a good answer treats it as a live argument with consequences for who reads, who teaches and who is translated.

Periods are useful but must be handled carefully. Pre-independence writing is often read through cultural nationalism; the post-war generation through disillusionment and experimental form; the contemporary period through diaspora, gender, migration and genre fiction. These labels describe tendencies, not rules.

Reading the text and the tradition together

Nigerian writing in English is multilingual in practice. Texts carry proverbs, songs, untranslated words and speech rhythms from Igbo, Yoruba, Hausa and Pidgin. The presence of these elements is not decoration: it positions the reader, creates authenticity effects and sometimes deliberately excludes the monolingual reader.

Oral tradition is a structural resource, not a theme. The praise singer, the folktale frame, the call-and-response rhythm and the digressive narrator all appear in written texts. When a novel uses a storyteller's voice, ask what that voice authorises: a moral perspective, a communal memory, or an ironic distance from the events narrated.

Gender is a sustained critical question. Early criticism focused on nation and culture; later work asked where women were in those narratives, and a generation of women writers re-entered the tradition on their own terms. Reading for gender does not mean judging characters by contemporary standards; it means asking how the text distributes voice, agency and consequence.

> **One quotation, three sentences of analysis**
> Never leave a quotation unexplained. Say what it says, how it is said, and what it does in the argument you are making.

Writing about literature

A literature essay argues about how meaning is produced. Plot summary is not analysis; it is the material you analyse. The strongest essays take a small textual detail - a repeated image, a shift in narrative voice, a character's silence - and use it to open a claim about the whole text.

Use the vocabulary precisely: narrator is not author; theme is not message; irony is not sarcasm. Cite by page in the edition you used. Compare texts by criterion, not in separate blocks.

Examiners reward the ability to hold a complexity. If a novel both criticises and reproduces a patriarchal assumption, say so and show where. A single-minded reading is easier to write and weaker to mark.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Turning summary into argument

A draft says: "In Things Fall Apart, Okonkwo is a strong man who refuses change and eventually kills himself."

1. Identify the problem: this reports plot and offers a psychological label.
2. Ask a question the text can answer: why does the novel place Okonkwo's rigidity against the flexibility of his community?
3. Draft a claim: the novel treats inflexibility not as individual flaw but as a structural risk in a society negotiating change.
4. Identify the evidence: the clan's willingness to adapt versus Okonkwo's fear of resemblance to his father.
5. Name a counter-reading: the novel also celebrates an uncompromising masculinity.
6. Conclude with a position that holds both.

> **What to carry forward**
> A claim about function beats a claim about personality.

2. Handling the language debate in an exam

"Discuss the argument that African literature should be written in African languages."

1. State both positions with their strongest reasons.
2. Give a textual example of English used to carry African idiom.
3. Give the counter-case: audience, education policy, translation.
4. Identify what the debate is really about: access and power, not aesthetics alone.
5. Conclude with your own position and what would follow from it.

> **What to carry forward**
> Present both cases at full strength before choosing.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Discuss the use of oral tradition in a Nigerian novel you have studied.

20 marks

1. Name the specific devices used: proverb, song, folktale, praise name, narrator address.
2. Give three textual instances with page references.
3. Explain the function of each: characterisation, communal authority, structure.
4. Assess whether the device is integrated or ornamental.
5. Conclude on what the novel gains from the oral resource.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Listing oral features without explaining what they do.

Q2. How does the language question shape the reading of Nigerian literature in English?

15 marks

1. State the debate and its main positions.
2. Show the textual consequence: idiom, untranslated terms, register shifts.
3. Explain the effect on the implied reader.
4. Relate to publishing, education and translation.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Cultural nationalism. Writing that asserts the value and autonomy of a colonised culture.

Oral tradition. Knowledge and art transmitted through speech, song and performance.

Proverb. A condensed traditional saying used to authorise an argument or judgement.

Code-switching. Alternating languages or registers within a text or utterance.

Narrator. The voice telling a story, distinct from the author.

Free indirect discourse. Third-person narration coloured by a character's idiom and perspective.

Postcolonial. Writing and criticism concerned with the legacies of colonial rule.

Hybridity. The mixing of cultural forms and languages produced by colonial encounter.

Canon. The body of texts a discipline treats as central, always contested.

Genre. A category of writing defined by shared conventions and reader expectations.

Disillusionment narrative. Post-independence writing that exposes the failure of nationalist promises.

Close reading. Detailed analysis of language and form in support of an interpretation.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Context

History of the field.

- Build a timeline of three generations.
- Summarise the language debate in 200 words.
- List the set texts with editions.

Week 2 - Close reading

Detail.

- Annotate one chapter for oral features.
- Choose three quotations worth analysing.
- Write 500 words on one image.

Week 3 - Argument

Thesis.

- Write two competing theses.
- Find the evidence each would need.
- Draft a five-paragraph plan.

Week 4 - Essay

Timed writing.

- Write a 20-mark answer in 40 minutes.
- Cut all plot summary.
- Check every quotation is analysed.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Achebe, Things Fall Apart and his essay on writing in English.
- Ngugi wa Thiong'o, Decolonising the Mind - for the language debate.
- A critical anthology of Nigerian literature covering the three generations.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is the difference between close reading and summary?

Answer: Summary reports events; close reading analyses how language makes meaning and supports an argument.

2. Name two phases of Nigerian literary history.

Answer: Cultural nationalism and independence-era disillusionment; civil-war writing and diaspora writing are further phases.

3. Why is biography an unreliable explanation on its own?

Answer: It reduces textual choices to authorial experience and ignores form, audience and literary tradition.

4. What should you do after quoting a line?

Answer: Analyse its diction, imagery or syntax and explain how it supports your claim.

5. Why does edition matter?

Answer: Pagination and textual variants differ between editions, so citations must name the edition used.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Build a timeline of four phases with one text each.
- [ ] Close-read one passage in 300 words.
- [ ] Annotate quotations in your set text.
- [ ] Write one argued paragraph with claim, evidence and analysis.
- [ ] Read one critical essay and summarise its argument.
- [ ] Check your citations against a single edition.
- [ ] Exchange essays and test each other's evidence.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

> **More from the ZikShare Academic Vault**
> Find faculty primers, study-skills guides, money and career packs, and digital-skills workbooks in the ZikShare Library. New packs are added every semester.

ZikShare Academic Vault | Faculty Primer | 100L | 2026 Fresher Edition

YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

ENG 101: Nigerian Literature in English - Texts, Contexts and Close Reading